

World in Brief: Shipping halted on the Strait of Hormuz; death toll in Venezuela rises



Photograph: AFP

Shipping was halted on the **Strait of Hormuz** after a Singapore-flagged cargo ship came under attack. American officials blamed Iran for what they said was a [drone strike](#). Earlier Iran warned ships only to use routes it had approved. The incident prompted the UN's International Maritime Organisation to pause its plans to evacuate sailors stranded in the strait. Oil prices also jumped in response.

The confirmed death toll from Wednesday's [earthquakes](#) in **Venezuela** reached 235. Rescuers continue to search through the rubble of hundreds of collapsed buildings. The two quakes were the country's largest—and possibly deadliest—in over a century. Countries around the world pledged support. America sent two navy ships and transport planes. The IMF committed \$200m to rebuild infrastructure, according to Delcy Rodríguez, Venezuela's acting president.

Volodymyr Zelensky authorised a 40-day blitz against **Russian** targets “to press for an end to the war”. The operation was agreed upon during a meeting between Ukraine's president and the head of its security services. Mr Zelensky did not provide more details on

the proposed assault, but said Ukrainian [forces had struck](#) two more oil refineries in Russia.

The **Trump administration** asked **OpenAI** to restrict the release of its latest model to government-approved partners before fully rolling it out. The artificial-intelligence firm is now expected to give access to GPT 5.6 to a handful of firms vetted by American officials. The request is another attempt by America to become the [gatekeeper for frontier AI models](#).

Shares in **Bayer** soared by more than 19% after a ruling by America's Supreme Court shielded the German firm from thousands of lawsuits. The claimants allege that Roundup, a weedkiller made by the firm, should carry a cancer warning. Bayer has been battling Roundup-related lawsuits since it bought Monsanto, the previous maker of the product, in 2018.

America's **Supreme Court** issued several rulings in line with the Trump administration's wishes. It determined that migrants could not claim asylum if they did not physically enter the country, enabling them to be turned back at the border. It also scrapped protections of Haitians' and Syrians' rights to work and live in the country. And it struck down a law restricting the right to carry guns in Hawaii.

Officials in **Paris** banned public boozing in an effort to ease pressure on hospitals during a **heatwave**. France's health-alert system was also raised to its highest level. Meteorologists are forecasting more scorching weather across Europe in the coming days. Temperatures in Germany are expected to touch 40°C on Friday. The heatwave is also [spreading](#) to eastern Europe.

Figure of the day: 143, the number of Chinese EV brands that sold at least one model last year. Read about the country's [strange and crowded industry](#).

Peace with Iran divides the Gulf

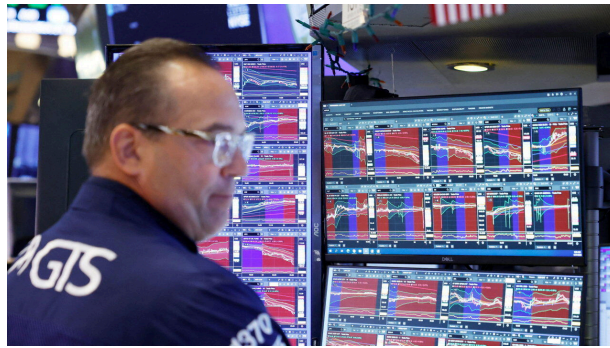


Photograph: Reuters

On Thursday Marco Rubio promised a group of Gulf foreign ministers that any [peace deal](#) struck between America and Iran would take them into account. America's secretary of state was speaking at the end of a three-day tour of Bahrain, Kuwait and the United Arab Emirates. His audience might well have been sceptical: Iran has attacked the Gulf with thousands of missiles and drones this year. And while [all six Gulf states](#) supported the ceasefire that was signed on June 17th, they doubt it will end the war for good—and disagree over what to do next.

Oman has tried to stay on friendly terms with Iran: this week it welcomed a high-level Iranian delegation. Saudi Arabia is more suspicious of the Islamic Republic, but open to diplomacy. (It hopes to organise reconciliation talks between Iran and Gulf countries soon.) The UAE sees Iran as an implacable foe; it prefers containment to conciliation. The Gulf is factious at the best of times. These are anything but.

A jittery week for tech stocks



Photograph: Alamy

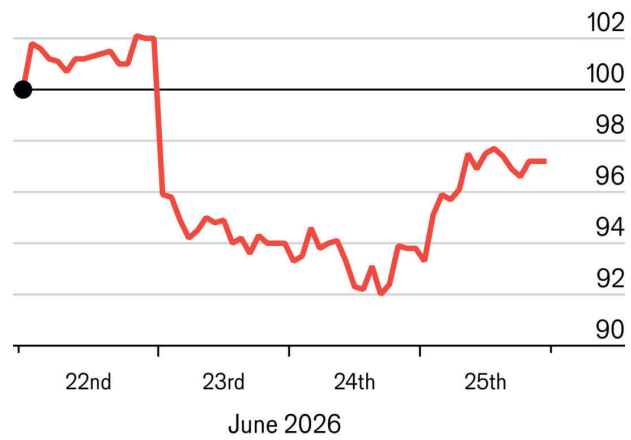
Over the next six years businesses will spend \$7.6trn on AI infrastructure, estimates Goldman Sachs Global Institute, part of the investment bank. Two-thirds will go towards [compute](#), the processors that train and run AI models. Such spending has propelled chipmakers' share prices to record highs.

But concerns about higher [interest rates in America](#), and doubts about the sort of forecasts Goldman Sachs is making, are testing those valuations. The expected stock-market debuts of OpenAI and Anthropic are prompting investors to question their optimistic assumptions about the chipmakers' biggest customers. Since Monday an index of leading semiconductor companies has dropped by 6%.

Micron Technology, an American memory-chip maker, eased worries on Wednesday, when it reported that its quarterly revenue had more than quadrupled from a year earlier. Such results suggest that AI spending has not yet slowed. Still in question, though, is whether chipmakers' customers will make enough profit to continue the spree.

Let the chips fall

PHLX semiconductor index,
June 22nd 2026 opening=100



Source: LSEG Workspace

Turkey's opposition in disarray



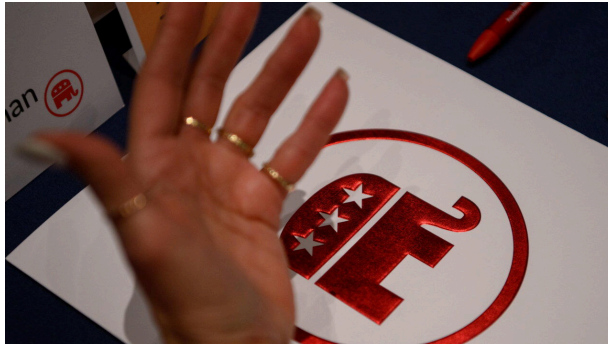
Photograph: Reuters

Last month a Turkish court ousted the Republican People's Party leader, Ozgur Ozel, and replaced him with Kemal Kilicdaroglu (pictured), the party's former chairman and loser of the 2023 presidential elections. It was the latest salvo in the war of attrition that Turkey's president, Recep Tayyip Erdogan, has been waging against [the country's democracy](#) and its main opposition group.

Mr Kilicdaroglu now faces open rebellion. Over 800 delegates are calling for an extraordinary congress to elect a new leader. Unless he takes action by Friday, the rebels will ask the courts to step in. But Mr Kilicdaroglu argues that preparations for a congress could only start in September. He has meanwhile begun a purge, ousting Mr Ozel's supporters from provincial leadership positions.

Mr Ozel faces a tough choice. Trying to wrest back control over the CHP risks a prolonged crisis. And there are major legal and financial hurdles to founding a rival party. Mr Erdogan has the CHP right where he wants it.

A financial GOPportunity



Photograph: Getty Images

On Friday conservative high-rollers will whip out their wallets at the Republican National Committee's finance retreat. The cheques they write will add to the RNC's cash advantage: as of May, the group had \$125m cash on hand, eight times more than the Democratic National Committee. Donald Trump's fundraising super-PAC is even richer, with nearly \$370m. Democratic donors are still skittish after the nightmare of 2024, when they spent more than \$6bn, only to lose both the White House and Congress.

But money may not be decisive in the midterm elections scheduled for November. Democratic voters, burning to punish the president, have been turning out in record numbers in several recent primaries and special elections. The party will probably win control of the House of Representatives, and perhaps the Senate, despite Republicans' cash advantage. The RNC will use the money it raises on Friday to fight [the midterms](#). But Mr Trump's PAC may wait to spend its cash on something else.

Europe suffers under sweltering heat



Photograph: Eyevine

Europeans have even more reason than usual to be thankful it's Friday. Western Europe has sweated through a [record-breaking heatwave](#) since last week: much of France and Spain endured over 40°C (104°F); Britain's Met Office issued its second-ever "red" warning, used when heat puts fit and healthy people at risk. Temperatures are forecast to drop this weekend.

But the damage will take longer to reveal itself. Hundreds of heat-related deaths in Spain have already been reported. In France over 48 people have drowned trying to cool off. Far more deaths will have actually occurred. During the 2022 European heatwave (the previous record holder), at least 60,000 people died across 35 countries. Scientists' best estimate is that climate change has made this week's weather 2-4°C hotter. With electricity grids straining under increased air-conditioning demand, schools closed and (in France) nuclear reactors shut down, the need for Europe to adapt faster is obvious.

Daily quiz



Illustration: Sandra Navarro

We will serve you a new question each weekday. On Friday your challenge is to give us all five answers and tell us the theme. Email your responses (and your home city and country) by 1700 BST on Friday to [\[email protected\]](#). We'll pick three winners at random and crown them on Saturday.

Friday: Which British-born officer is generally regarded as the “father of the American Navy” for his exploits in the Revolutionary war?

Thursday: Which American oil tycoon haggled with the kidnappers when his grandson was taken in 1973?

*Above all, be the heroine of your
life, not the victim.*

Nora Ephron